

The Warwick Innovation District

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Andrew Harrison

Managing Director, Head of NatWest Business Banking

Foreword

A thriving economy is dependent on a flourishing entrepreneurial culture, and this new report shines a spotlight on the vibrant entrepreneurial ecosystem that continues to grow in the West Midlands. The findings show that the variety of sectors, level of investment and size of network at play in this part of the country make it an increasingly important part of the UK economy. As a result, NatWest continues to grow its presence and commitment to supporting SMEs in the area — but this is a team sport, and regional support collaboration and partnership are key.

This report shows that the University of Warwick produces nearly 30% of spinout businesses in the West Midlands region, with equity raised of nearly £36m, which is why our recently opened Accelerator hub at the University is a central strand of our strategy in this part of the UK. It allows NatWest to support up-and-coming, high growth entrepreneurs and businesses across growing sectors such as interactive entertainment, deeptech and high value manufacturing to become future success stories. It also encourages future business owners to consider these new sectors alongside the more traditional, high growth sectors in this region such as property, automotive and food and drink.

Our Accelerator hub is part of our wider network of 14 Enterprise Hubs, which is one of the largest of its kind across the UK and provides not only training and physical workspaces, but also coaching and access to peers and sector specialists. We know that start-ups are having to do several jobs at once — the CEO, Finance Director and HR

Manager — the bank's accelerator programme is designed to help them be all those things whilst supporting them in running their business.

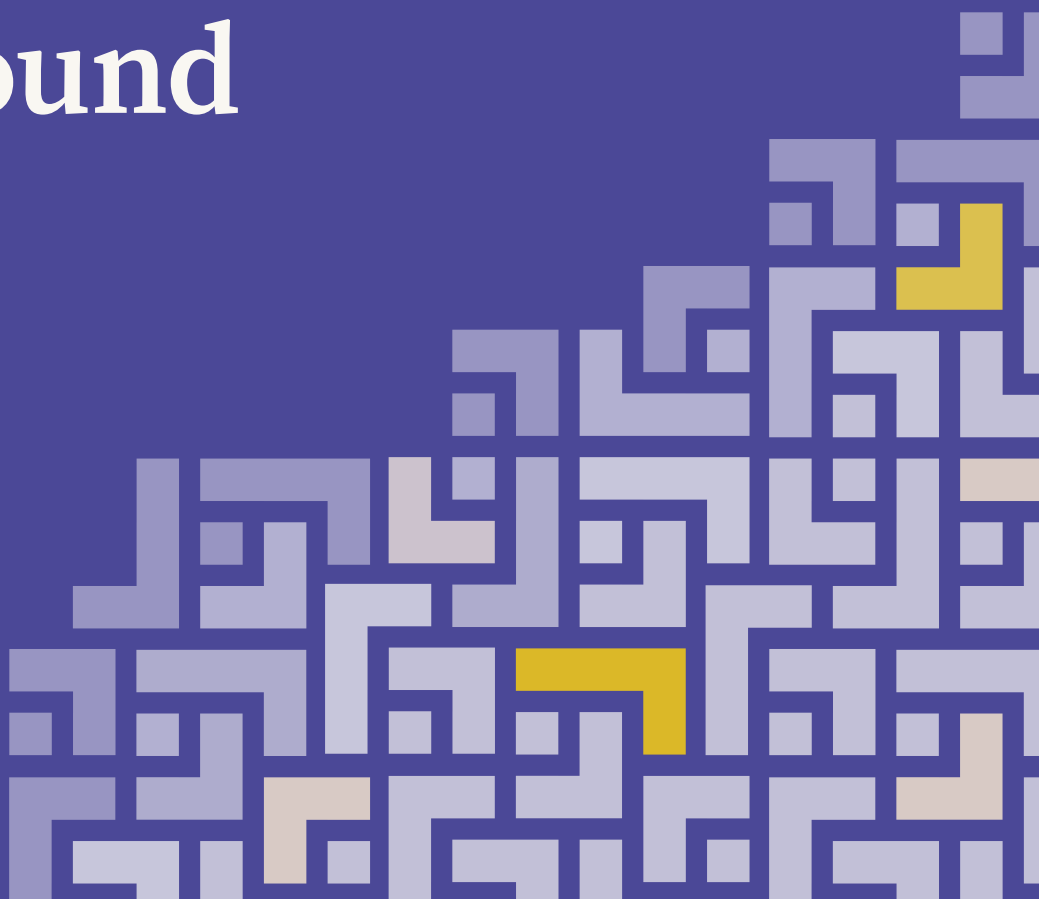
Over the past four years the programme has supported more than 3,500 individuals and businesses, helping them achieve an average turnover of £301,521 and to raise £198m in total investments. These hubs work in conjunction with our wider ambitions for the future economy — looking at today's cohort, 39% of places are devoted to sustainability focused business, 47% have gone to female entrepreneurs, over 20% to ethnic minority businesses and 75% are outside London and the South East.

What this report shows is that the many different businesses and sectors at play in the region are vital to the recovery of the UK's economy. Continued collaborative working with all parts of the entrepreneurial ecosystem, including other financial institutions and lenders, is crucial if we are to get these funding structures right for entrepreneurs and start-ups.

As we come out of the pandemic, and despite rising inflation and a cost of living crisis, now is a great time to start a new business and become an entrepreneur. There's more support than ever in terms of access to grants and funding, networking and mentoring and angel investment. And as the biggest lender to businesses, we are determined to play our part.

The team at NatWest looks forward to working closely with partners such as University of Warwick and Beaufhurst to help the West Midlands' future business success stories start, scale and thrive.

Background



The building blocks of Innovation at Warwick

Delivering innovation, nurturing talent and helping businesses to capitalise on opportunities is possible at Warwick, due to its highly engaged and diverse ecosystem built on strong foundations:



The University of Warwick has a rich history of supporting creativity, business partnerships and entrepreneurship across many disciplines. Warwick understands that innovation occurs at the intersection of customer pain points, fundamental research and emerging technologies when diverse communities, disciplines and talents work together in concert.

To truly realise the potential, Warwick appointed a Chief Innovation Officer and created the Warwick Innovation District (WID). The introduction of this conductor role leading an Innovation Group allowed WID to build a multi-disciplinary innovation-ecosystem well equipped to tackle the challenges of the future.

The Warwick Innovation District has evidenced its capacity to address the opportunities available with more than 8000 people engaging across University talent, investors and the region's businesses. Powered by the University of Warwick, WID has grown to become a large, open community that stretches from London where it holds Angel investor sessions to the University Hospitals Coventry and Warwickshire NHS Trust (UHCW), through Silicon Spa to its Innovation campus in Wellesbourne. WID brings together academics, founders and investors with the aim of making an impact for society and the West Midlands region, by launching and scaling businesses, and providing students with the opportunity to experiment and innovate.

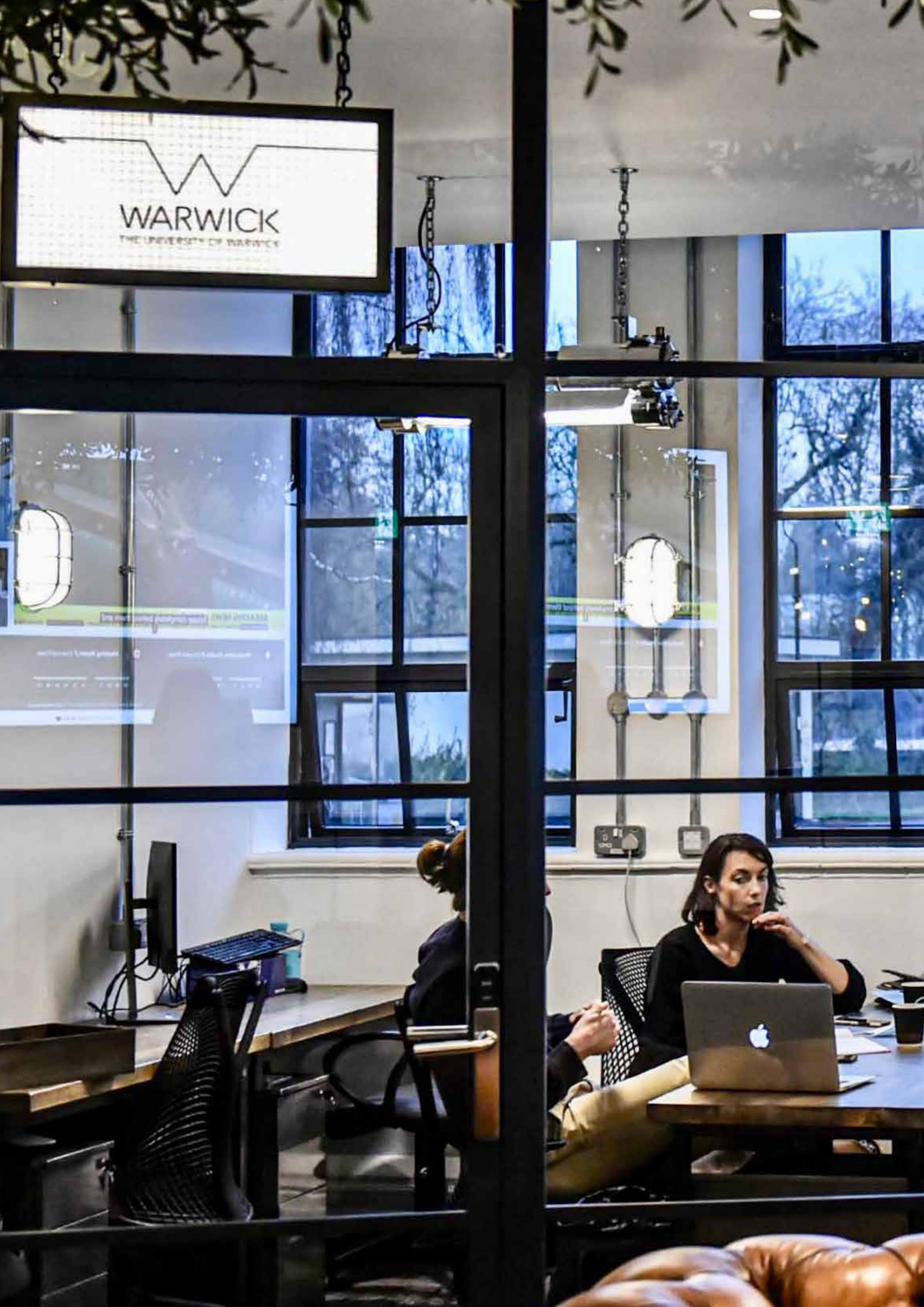
Warwick also delivers the chance for academics from other universities, such as Oxford, Birmingham, and Nottingham, to participate in the ICUR programme funded and run by Innovate UK. This incredible programme commercialises and accelerates research from academics, resulting in increased spinouts and diversity within WID.

The specialisms within WID span a broad spectrum of industries, focusing on challenges relevant to the modern socio-economic and political context. One example of this is through the Deep Tech Innovation Centre — an incubator programme aimed at supporting students, researchers, alumni and startup companies working in areas including AI, Blockchain, Quantum Computing and Robotics. This programme recognises the innovation available in this field, and supports companies using original scientific and engineering research to address global problems.

The Warwick Innovation District has also become engaged with challenges relating to sustainability, embracing this field as an industry rife with opportunities. The West Midlands, as noted in the Government's Levelling Up White Paper, will be a key region for supporting the energy transition within the transport sector. In line with these findings, the Warwick Manufacturing Group (WMG) has partnered with NatWest to develop a Clean Transport Specialist Accelerator, which is a unique place to access research, test centres, support with supply chains and business coaching.



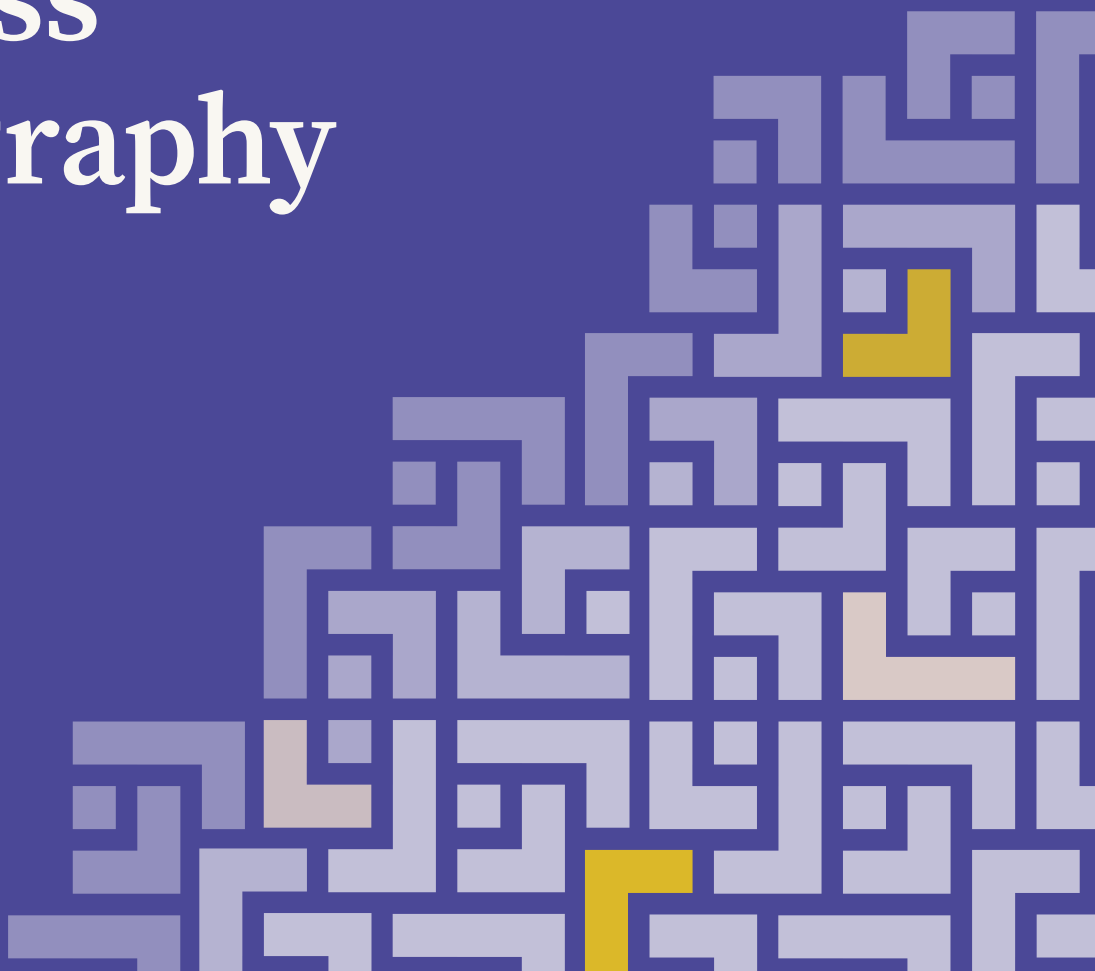
The National Automotive Innovation Centre at the University of Warwick.



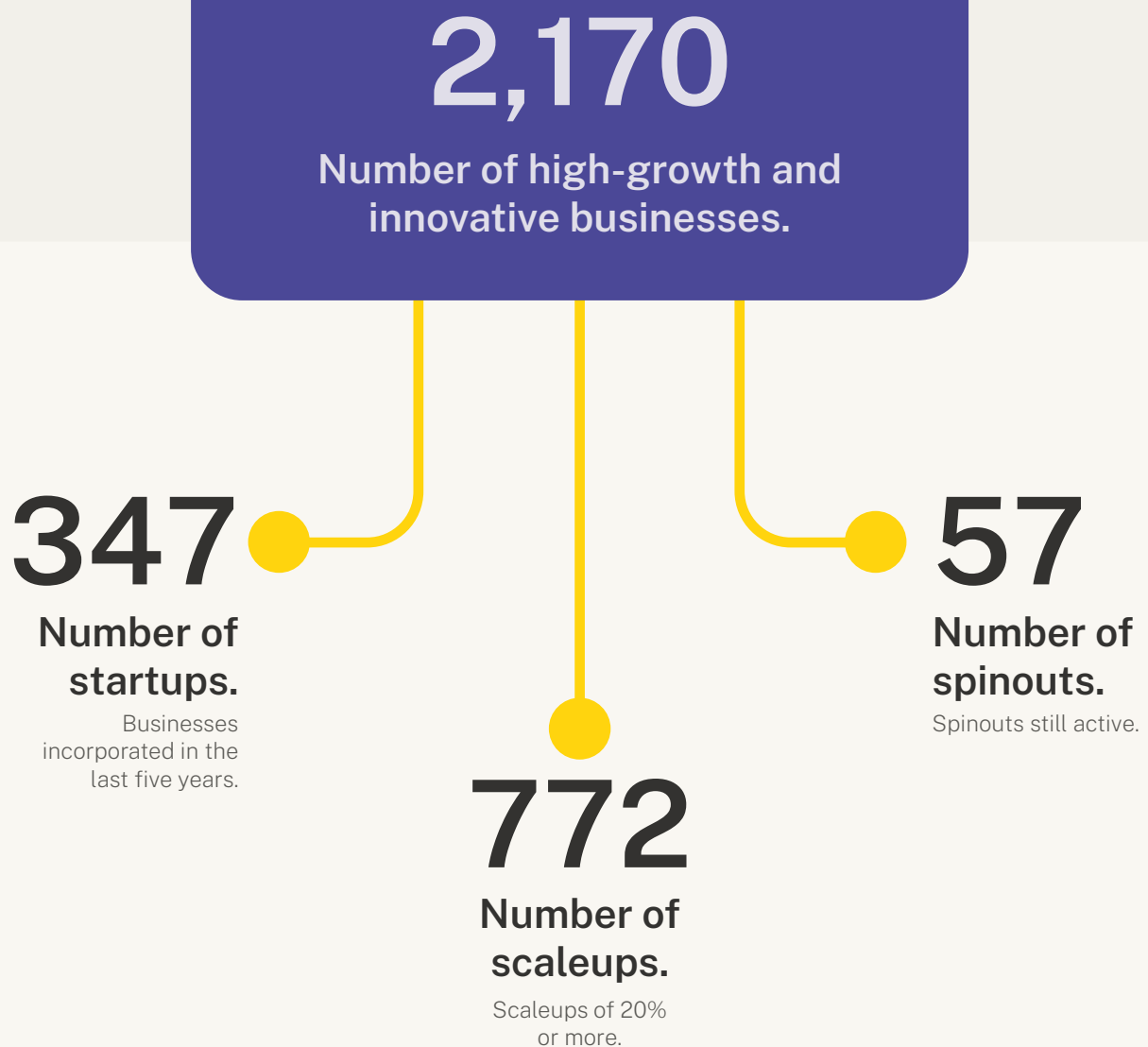
WARWICK
THE UNIVERSITY OF WARWICK



Business Demography



The business population of the West Midlands



Top sectors

Top sectors by the number of high-growth companies in the West Midlands (2022)

Property/land development and construction	147
Distribution	132
Automotive	123
Food and drink processors	123
Software-as-a-service (SaaS)	112
Analytics, insight, tools	97
Machinery	91
E-commerce	90
Internet platform	89
Mobile apps	88

In the West Midlands, the most popular sector for high-growth companies is property/land development and construction. The industry represents 6.77% of the region's 2,170 active businesses, which is higher than the 5.73% of companies working in this sector across the UK.

Tech companies are also well represented within the top sectors in Warwickshire and Coventry, with the sub-sectors Software-as-

a-Service (25), internet platform (19), mobile apps (18), and analytics, insight, tools (18) ranking highly by business population. These findings align with trends across the broader UK high-growth ecosystem, as tech-related industries have continued to grow over the last decade. Other key sectors in Warwickshire and Coventry include e-commerce (26), distribution (24) and property/land development and construction (24).

Local major employers



Jaguar Land Rover

Headquartered in Coventry, Jaguar Land Rover is one of the most well-known employers in the West Midlands. The firm is a subsidiary of Tata Motors Ltd, formed after a 2013 merger between Jaguar and Land Rover to become one company. The multinational car manufacturer reported a turnover of £16.5b and more than 30,000 employees across the UK in its 2021 financials.



BT

BT is the largest provider of fixed-line, broadband and mobile services in the UK. Though headquartered in London, the telecommunications firm employs more than 11,000 people in the West Midlands. In 2021, BT also opened a regional hub in Birmingham with the intention of creating 1,000 jobs in the city. The Three Snowhill development in Birmingham's business district offers a number of amenities to staff and hopes to eventually be a space for 3,000 employees.



NatWest

Incorporated in 1968, Natwest was formed through the merger of National Provincial Bank and Westminster Bank. It later joined the Royal Bank of Scotland Group, which was then renamed NatWest Group in 2020. The bank employs around 60,000 people in the UK. Natwest also runs the largest Accelerator programme in the UK which has supported over 30,000 entrepreneurs, including a hub at the University of Warwick, open to all.

Sector spotlights

Gaming

In recent years, gaming companies have become more prevalent within the high-growth ecosystem thanks to the increased array of affordable technologies and infrastructure, combined with more sophisticated digital distribution strategies and consumer demand. The West Midlands is a key gaming hub for the UK, with a number of studios calling the region home. A number of larger gaming companies have also opened local bases in Leamington Spa, including SEGA, Ubisoft, and Codemasters. Gaming markets continue to grow strongly and the recent launch of the Warwick Esports Centre has seen an important acceleration.

33

companies with HQ in
the West Midlands

Digital and creative

Digital and creative refers to companies working in digital media and the online publishing industry. In the West Midlands, there are 30 companies in this sector, ranging from content creators to platform-based communities. The opportunities in this field have been created by the dramatically reduced costs involved in creating and distributing digital content thanks to advances in visual media technology and the proliferation of social media networks. Businesses, such as health and wellbeing platform Kaido and On The Tools, which has created a content driven community for the construction industry, have capitalised on these trends by providing niche content.

30

companies with HQ in
the West Midlands

Sector spotlights

Deeptech

Deeptech companies are those which create value via tangible engineering innovation or scientific advances and discoveries, such as Artificial Intelligence, robotics, blockchain, biotechnology and quantum computing. In the West Midlands, there are 55 companies working in this space, including autonomous vehicle software developer Eatron Technologies, optical technologist EYOTO, and 3D content development tool Haiper.

55

companies with HQ in
the West Midlands

High-value manufacturing

High-value manufacturing refers to businesses using knowledge-intensive techniques to produce high-value and high-cost products. These companies range from small social enterprises to global giants, with 101 businesses in this space choosing the West Midlands for their home location. Another firm attracted to the region is Lotus Cars, which is establishing an advanced technology centre and University partnership at the Wellesbourne Innovation campus. The facility will also be a base for Lotus' engineering consultancy.

101

companies with HQ in
the West Midlands

Sector spotlights

Medtech

Innovation is rife in the medtech field, with a large number of companies using the latest technological advancements to address medical challenges. Companies in this area range from those using Artificial Intelligence to expedite drug discovery, to others leveraging the cloud to store large datasets that can be shared amongst doctors. There are 36 companies in the West Midlands working in this field, including portable dialysis developer Quanta, diagnostic specialists Creavo, and 4D Biomaterials – a company that creates 3D printing technology that can be used in medicine.

36

companies with HQ in
the West Midlands

Emergent sectors

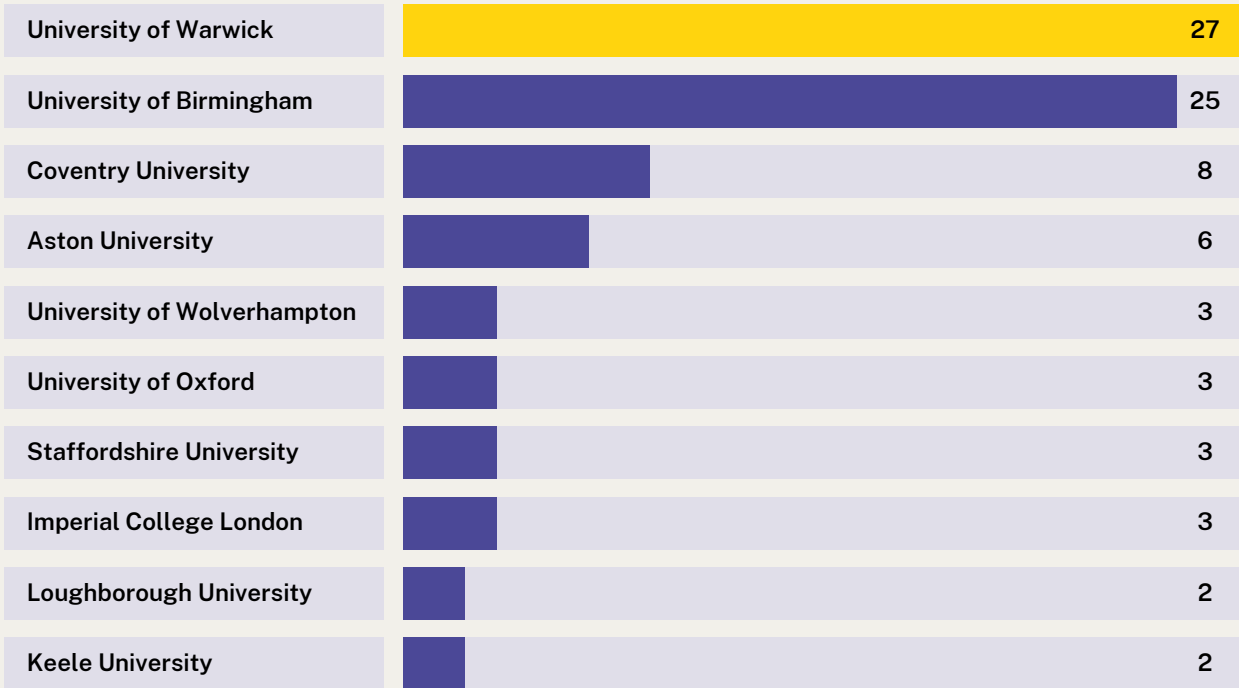
There are 229 high-growth companies in the West Midlands operating in emergent sectors. These are sectors that sit at the intersection of traditional sectors, such as finance and education, with new technologies such as automation and artificial intelligence. Examples include increasingly popular fields such as 3D printing, biofuels, challenger banks, edtech, gamification, robotics, smart homes, and urban farming. Many companies in this area are tackling important global problems such as how to feed a growing population and how to reduce inequality through education.

229

companies with HQ in
the West Midlands

Spinouts

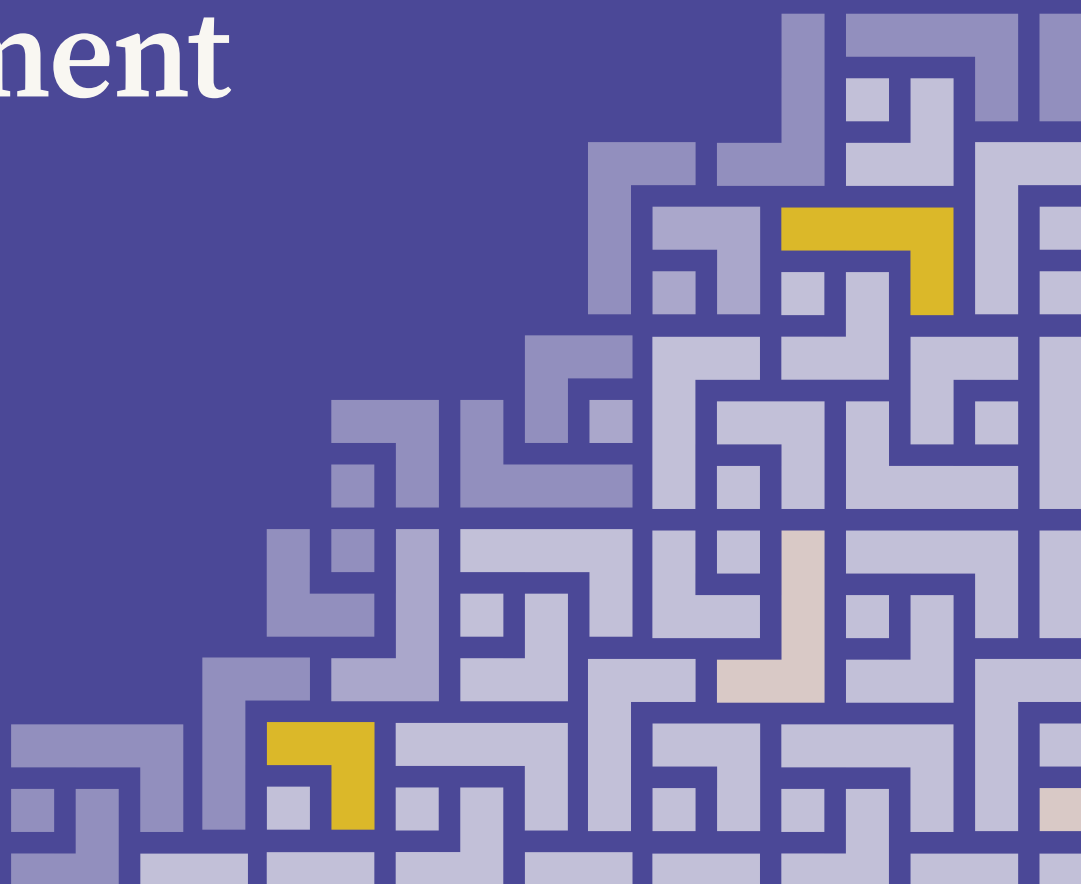
Top institutions by the number of spinout companies in the West Midlands (2022)



There are 91 companies based in the West Midlands that have spun out from academic institutions. The most popular university for commercialising research is the University of Warwick, which has spun out 29.7% of the businesses in the region. This finding highlights the core role played by the University within the local business community, as the institution maintains close geographical ties with a number of spinout companies.

Another key research centre for the West Midlands region is the University of Birmingham. Although based in a neighbouring region, the institution has spun out 25 businesses that have subsequently based their operations in the West Midlands. Other universities that have contributed towards the innovation within the region include Coventry University (8), also based in the West Midlands, and Aston University (6).

Investment

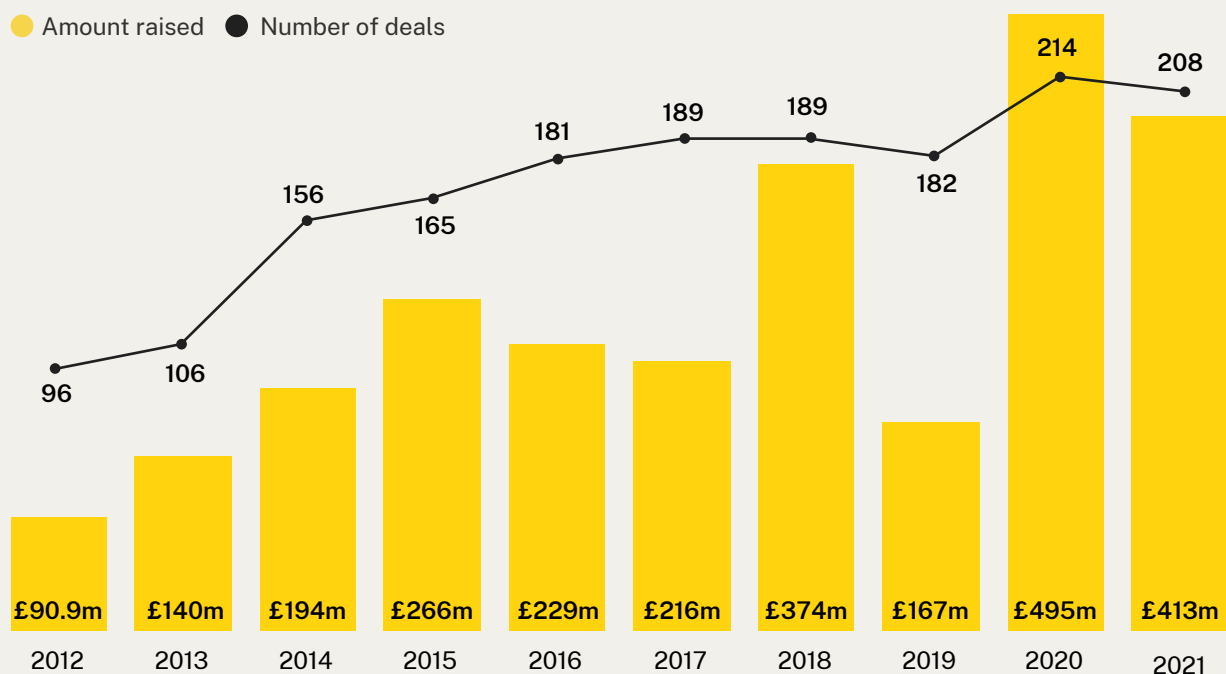


Equity investment

The number, and value, of deals invested into companies based in Warwickshire and Coventry has continued to grow over the past decade. Between 2012 and 2021, the value of equity investment quadrupled, rising from £90.9m to £413m. The number of deals taking place increased significantly, increasing from 96 investment rounds taking place in 2012 to 208 occurring in 2021. The largest year for equity growth took place between 2019 and 2020, when the value of fundraisings into companies

based in the West Midlands increased by 196% in a single year. These results contradict the patterns observed in the broader high-growth ecosystem, where between 2019 and 2020 the value of equity raised dropped as a result of the COVID-19 pandemic. The peculiar success of the region during this time frame may explain why the number, and value, of deals taking place dropped between 2020 and 2021, whilst the broader private markets blossomed.

Equity investment by combined value and number of deals per year into companies in the West Midlands (2012-2021)



Top investors

Top investors by the number of deals in companies in the West Midlands (2012-2021)

Minerva Business Angel Network*	52
Mercia Fund Managers	44
Crowdcube	43
Midlands Engine Investment Fund	41
Seedrs	30
SyndicateRoom	23
Early Advantage Fund	23
BGF Growth Capital	22
Exceed Partnership	11
Mercia EIS Fund	10

*Minerva Business Angel Network is part of the University of Warwick Science Park.

The University of Warwick's partnership with Plug and Play

In 2022, Plug and Play partnered with the University of Warwick as well as the Advanced Propulsion Centre and Zenzic to launch a mobility programme. Based at the institution's National Automotive Innovation Centre, the University of Warwick is the programme's founding academic partner in the UK. Plug and Play is an early-stage investor and open innovation platform — the partnership will attract global investors, opening new investment opportunities for Warwickshire's high-potential businesses. Plug and Play is also working with a leading business in the region, Jaguar Land Rover, on developing an innovation hub.

Top investees

Top companies in Warwickshire and Coventry by the total value of equity investment secured (2012-2021)

Quanta	£246m
Proton Partners International	£205m
Gymshark	£200m
Pritt Group	£108m
Hayfield Homes	£85.0m
Roxhill	£65.0m
Keltruck	£49.7m
Birmingham Bio Power	£47.8m
Market Location	£42.0m
Shire Leasing	£40.0m

The top company by the value of equity investment secured between 2012 and 2021 was Quanta, which develops portable dialysis devices that can be used for both clinical and home treatments. Based in Stratford-upon-avon, the business has secured £246m of equity investment across five fundraising rounds. The most recent of these took place in June 2021, with the company raising £173m with an accompanying valuation of £200m.

Following Quanta, Proton Partners International has raised the second largest amount of equity investment, securing £205m between 2012 and 2021. The company launched in 2015 and ran therapy centres used for cancer treatment prior to its exit via IPO in February 2019. Other companies that have raised large volumes of equity investment include Gymshark (£200m), Pritt Group (£108m), and Hayfield Homes (£85m).

Investment into spinouts

Top institutions in the West Midlands by the amount of equity raised by their spinout companies (2021)

University of Warwick	£35.8m
University of Birmingham	£23.1m
Aston University	£4.50m
Coventry University	£350k
University of Wolverhampton	-
Keele University	-

Considering spinouts are an opportunity for university researchers to commercialise their most innovative and valuable research, it is no surprise that investors are often very interested in this type of business. Universities with top research facilities and cutting-edge technology are likely to have more spinout companies which may go on to raise equity investment as they are able to offer these spaces for research.

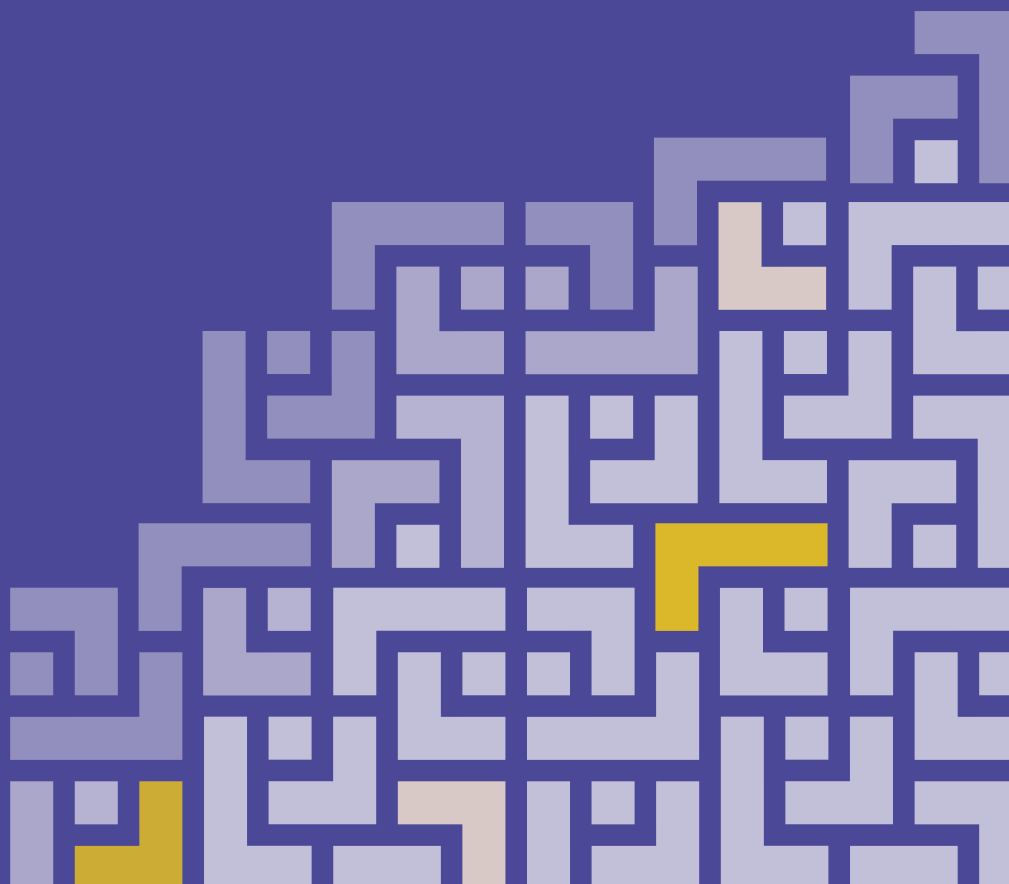
The regional leader of the West Midlands for institutions by the amount of equity raised by its spinouts is the University of Warwick — these companies secured £35.8m in 2021. Contributing to this total was an £11.7m deal

into Lightcast Discovery, which creates cell manipulation technology for drug discovery, and a £6.2m deal into NanoSyrinx, which develops nanotechnology for drug delivery to the interior of cells. Among all institutions across the whole of the UK, the University of Warwick ranked ninth, with the leaders being Oxford and Cambridge.

The universities of Birmingham, Aston, and Coventry also have spinout companies that raised equity investment in 2021. Although spinouts from the universities of Wolverhampton and Keele did not secure any equity deals in 2021, they have done so in previous years.

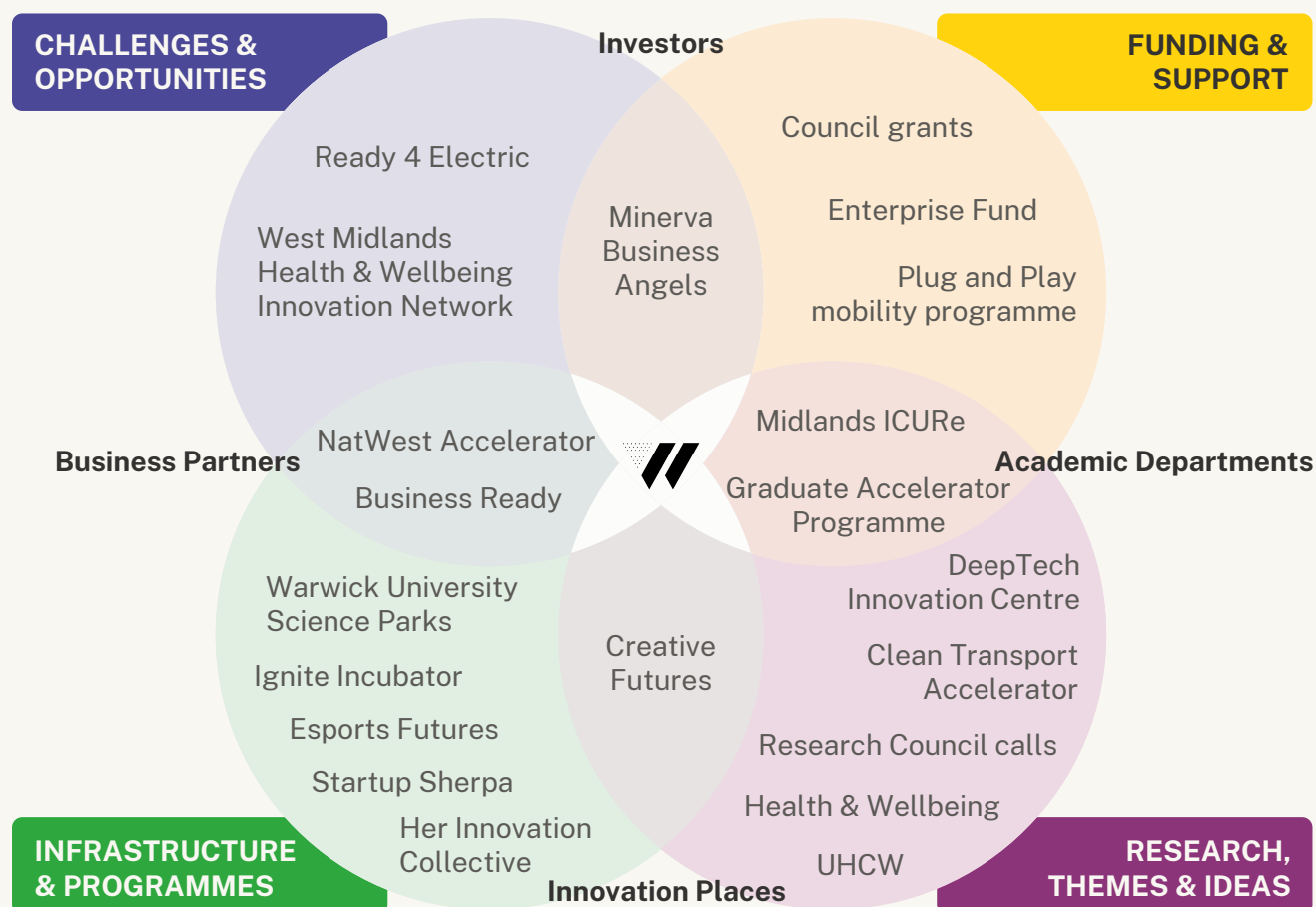


Ecosystem Support



Spotlight nodes

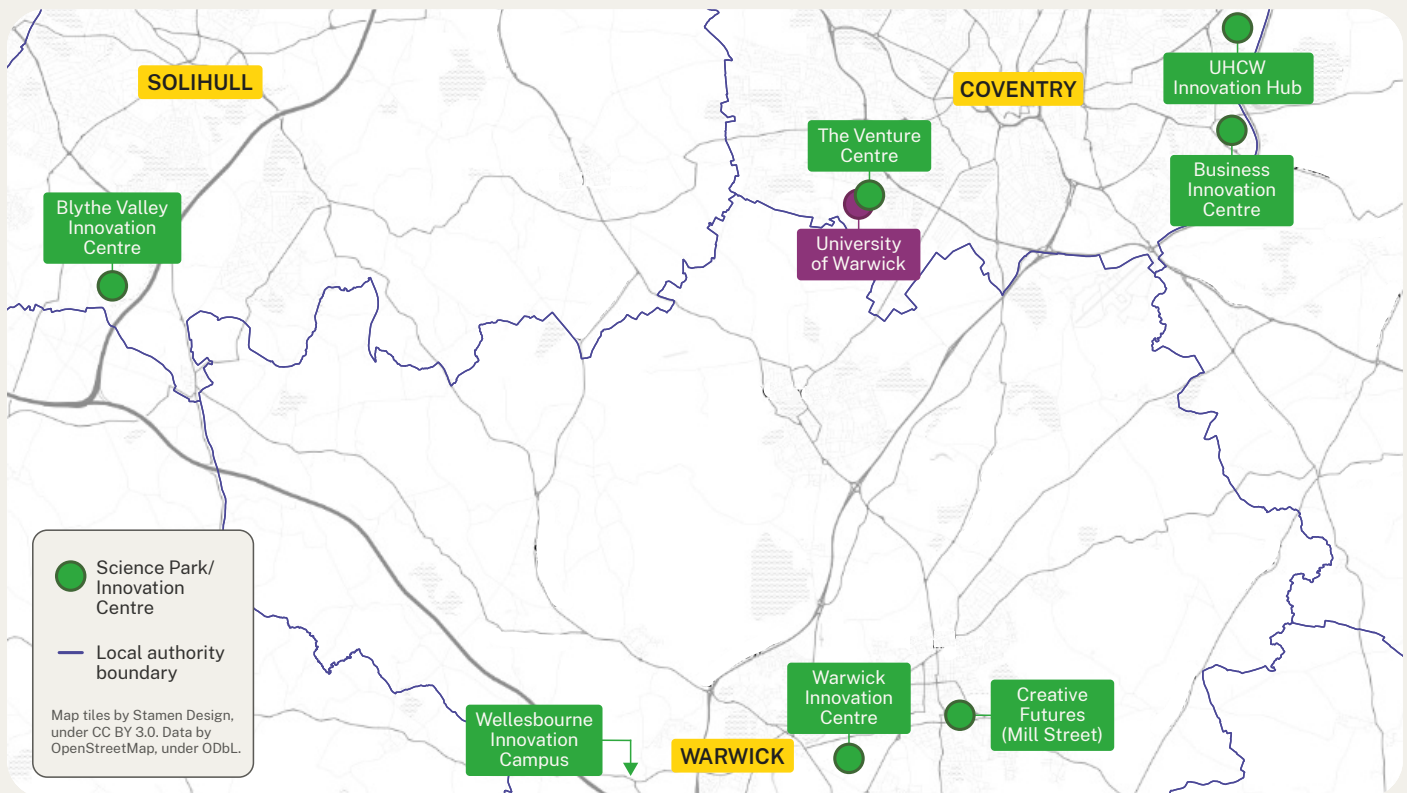
Components of the Warwick Innovation District



Embracing the challenges that arise when building healthy and robust businesses, the Warwick Innovation District has constructed an environment with several nodes that encourage both innovation and diversity. These nodes have various themes that often overlap, working to embrace challenges and seize opportunities, help businesses locate funding and support, whilst also boost growth through infrastructure

and programmes. Finally, WID's nodes are also seizing the research, themes and ideas that stem from the world-leading teaching and academic excellence of the University of Warwick. Moreover, the nodes create networks and opportunities for businesses to meet with investors, find business partners, utilise innovation places, and collaborate with academic departments.

University of Warwick Science Parks and Innovation Centres



The Venture Centre, University of Warwick

Based at the University of Warwick, the Venture Centre is designed to provide starter space for new tech companies, step up accommodation for more established businesses as well as scale up units in the Science Park for companies who see themselves requiring larger office or lab space for up to 250 staff.

Business Innovation Centre, Coventry

The office space at the Business Innovation Centre is a joint venture between Coventry City Council, Coventry & Warwickshire Chamber of Commerce, and the University of Warwick. The building was constructed aiming to allow companies to collaborate with these partners to create and foster their innovation and growth.

Warwick Innovation Centre, Warwick

The Warwick Innovation Centre is a prestigious location near to Silicon Spa for start up and small innovative businesses, offering purpose-designed accommodation on short leases.

The location and connections of the Science Park's innovation centres allow companies to access extensive business services from the University's science park management as well as access to the Science Park's business support team on application. All Innovation Centres have links to the University of Warwick to foster knowledge exchange and access vital skills. The Innovation Centres are also chosen by larger national or international firms, establishing their first UK office or a regional branch, bringing supply chains closer together.

WBS at the Shard

Located at the heart of the London Bridge Quarter neighbourhood, in one of London's most vibrant districts, Warwick Business School offers postgraduate courses and extensive education from the capital's iconic Shard building.

Opened in July 2012, WBS London houses two lecture theatres, eight seminar rooms and an IT lab designed by Italian architect Renzo Piano.

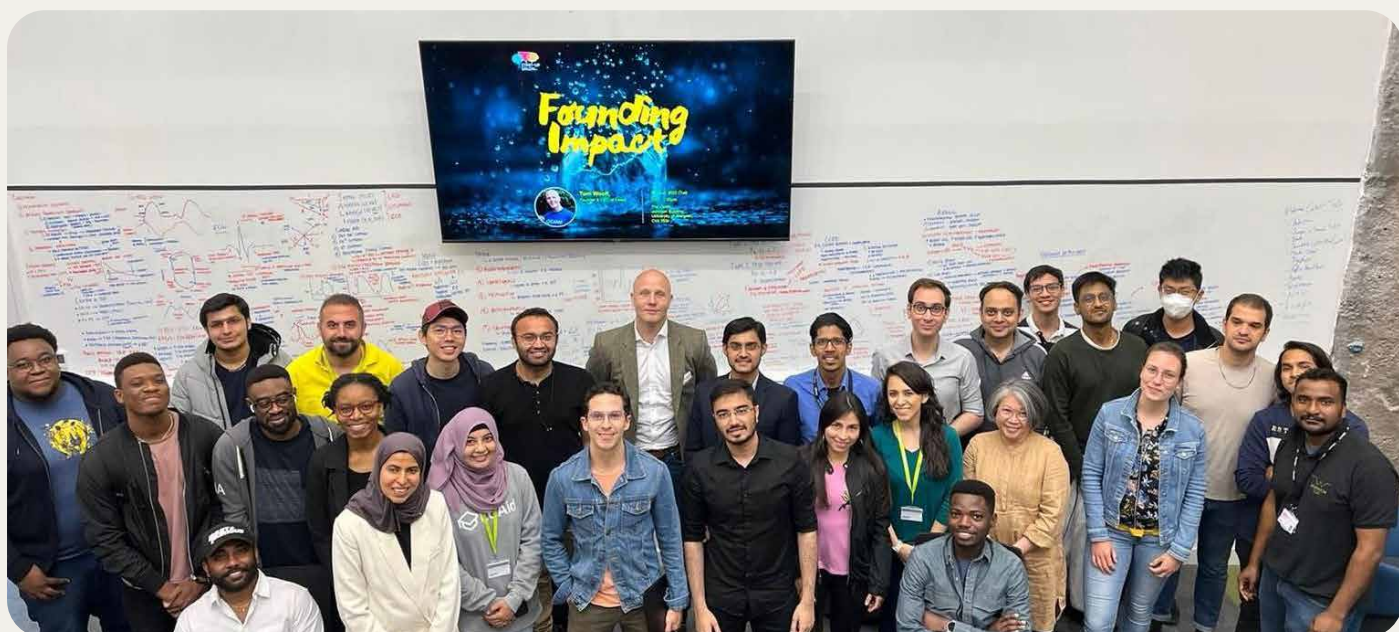
Creative Futures

Powered by the University of Warwick, Creative Futures is an incubator programme that offers a gateway between the University and the region's creative businesses.

The programme inspires and educates individuals, offering space, business support, mentoring, and networking opportunities with the aim of supporting growth, creative ideas, enterprises, and innovation.



Promotional material for Creative Futures.



The Climb, University of Warwick.

Wellesbourne Innovation Campus

The Innovation Campus at Wellsbourne aims to foster the development of creative ideas. Hosting more than 400 individuals, the Campus has a strong presence of life sciences, having constructed an environment that facilitates leading food, environment and agriculture research.

The Innovation Campus offers businesses the opportunity to locate themselves in a hub that encourages co-creation between academic and industry excellence, working closely with diverse regional partners and the surrounding community.

The Climb

Located in the heart of the University of Warwick Campus, the Climb is host to a range of events and activities to support the incubation and acceleration of businesses on our Clean Transport, Health and Wellbeing, NatWest, Graduate and student incubator programmes.

With free hotdesking for participants and links to other academic expertise and technology, it is a great place to develop business.



University Hospitals Coventry and Warwickshire NHS Trust Innovation Hub

University Hospitals Coventry and Warwickshire NHS Trust Innovation Hub

The Innovation Hub at the University Hospitals Coventry and Warwickshire NHS Trust is a specialist space designed to drive innovation and transformation while ensuring patient interests are at the forefront of their priorities. The space aims to achieve four key goals, with the centre encouraging individuals to dream, think, create and influence. Working in a hub built around these values and aspirations encourages innovation, flexibility and collaboration amongst users. Working in collaboration with the University of Warwick and the West Midlands Health and Wellbeing Innovation Network, they provide a programme of activity to create solutions to real health challenges with the SME community.



Warwick Esports Centre

Esports Centre

In response to novel research emphasising the link between gaming and innovation brain functions, the University of Warwick launched an Esports Centre that provides students and the local community the opportunity to practice, and gain, relevant skills. The Esports Centre hosts a series of events, including Esports Future. Funded by the UK Government through the UK Community Renewal Fund, the programme aims to implement the UK Government's goals of levelling up by investing in people, place, and communities. This is achieved through Esports Futures, as participants between the ages of 16 and 24 are taken on a two day experience where they learn a wide array of soft skills.

West Midlands Health & Wellbeing Innovation Network

Funded by the West Midlands Combined Authority, the West Midlands Health & Wellbeing Innovation Network is driven by the University of Warwick in partnership with University Hospitals Coventry and Warwickshire NHS Trust and Bruntwood SciTech. With the health and wellbeing of the nation recovering from challenging times, the network aims to help address real world health challenges by fostering and developing innovation.

The programme seeks to encourage interested businesses and SMEs to create solutions, while the network aids their development with the provision of support, space, networks and mentoring. These partnerships will enable the creation and commercialisation of innovative solutions for the benefit of the health and economy of the region and the nation.

Deep Tech Innovation Centre

The Deep Tech Innovation Centre supports students, researchers, alumni and local startup companies to explore the commercial potential of their innovations in areas ranging from advanced materials and biotechnology to blockchain, quantum computing and robotics. The one thing they all have in common is that they are using original scientific and engineering research to offer innovative solutions to global problems.

Deep Tech businesses require a great amount of support; the Deep Tech Innovation Centre offers space in facilities, access to university resources, entrepreneurship training, mentoring to become investment-ready, and networking opportunities.



Ignite Incubator

Ignite is a flexible package of advice and practical help, designed to allow startup and early-stage companies to tap into the resources of the University of Warwick Science Park and its wealth of know-how. These incubator programmes are aimed at supporting budding entrepreneurs through the process of developing a business model to aid with new product development and overcome obstacles relating to starting up a business.

Ignite provides qualifying startups with 12 months subsidised office space in three of its innovation centres as well as support from its virtual incubator for start ups that do not require a physical base. Ignite has one aim — to help the owners and managers of innovation-led businesses realise their company aspirations. Through the incubator, the University of Warwick Science Park can offer support that will facilitate growth now and in the long term. In the last three years, Ignite has reached 583 individuals through workshops, supporting 290 pre-starts and startups.



Midlands ICURE

As one of the UK's most active accelerators, Innovation to Commercialisation of University Research (ICURE) is a three month customer discovery programme designed using lean startup methodology and funded by Innovate UK.

ICURE trains, funds and supports teams led by university early-career researchers to determine whether there is a market for products or services that utilise their research, science or technology. Up to £35,000 of funding is available to "get out of the lab" and validate these commercially promising ideas in the marketplace. A large number of ICURE graduates go on to raise further equity after attending the accelerator.

Business Ready programme

Business Ready is an innovative business support programme that is part funded by the European Regional Development Fund (ERDF) and Warwickshire County Council. It aims to assist tech-based SMEs that are based within the Coventry and Warwickshire area. Business Ready offers fresh perspectives for business owners to help turn their ideas into reality.

The business support team have expertise and experience supporting, advising, coaching and mentoring growth businesses. The topics covered by the Business Ready programme include raising finance, business planning, new product development, market research, sales planning and more. They also address skills gaps in businesses by offering a wide range of free business workshops. In the last three years, Business Ready has upskilled with 873 people, supporting 107 businesses to create 75 jobs.

Clean Transport Accelerator

The NatWest Entrepreneur Accelerator is working with Warwick Manufacturing Group at the University of Warwick, to create a Clean Transport Specialist Accelerator, combining coaching, thought leadership, community, and access to networks, with specialist support from members of the High Value Manufacturing Catapult.

The UK has world leading research and innovation capability, but it can be difficult to navigate support structures to find the help needed to develop both the solution, and the commercial strategy to grow the business. The Clean Transport Specialist Accelerator was created to address these challenges, and to help remove barriers and encourage growth.



WMG headquarters, University of Warwick.

Minerva Business Angels

Powered by the University of Warwick Science Park, Minerva is a network of business angels based in the Midlands, London and Northwest but has investors from all over the UK. The group has institutional collaborations with the universities of Aston, Birmingham, Loughborough, Nottingham, Nottingham Trent, Warwick Business School plus Sci-Tech Daresbury.

The network has supported over 100 companies ranging from urban transport company EAV, Medtech business Lightpoint Medical, telecoms company Genesis Telecommunications to Edtech business Learning Labs. Between 2011 and 2021, Minerva was the second most active angel network in the UK, behind Envestors and ahead of Cambridge Angels, 24Haymarket, and Archangels. They were also identified as the UK's second most active investor in the green tech space.

Ready for Electrification

Ready for electrification (R4E) was a series of themed virtual events hosted by the University of Warwick between March and October 2020 developed specifically for UK manufacturers that are currently supplying, or have an interest in supplying, to the transport electrification sector.

The events were focused on electric machines and power electronic drivelines, life cycle, recycle and reuse opportunities in transport electrification, micromobility, and electricity networks and charging.

Her Innovation Collective

Warwick Enterprise launched Her Innovation Collective in September 2019 to deliver an exciting opportunity for students to engage with leading women in innovation from sectors such as tech, marketing, finance, social enterprise and startups.

The programmes aimed to build a passionate community of students and professional women who create, inspire and lead with discussions centering around innovation, entrepreneurship, assessing failures, and how to achieve success. Moreover, the collective also provided students with networking experience, enabling them to build relationships with inspiring individuals that could support their personal and professional development.



Startup Sherpa

Warwick Enterprise partnered with the Startup Sherpa platform to bring a revolutionary digital space where students can start their own startup guided day by day through the process of “How” to turn an idea into a startup. The Startup Sherpa programme is just 25 minutes a day with a single mission to complete.

Through a super-simple step-by-step daily task approach to building your own startup, the programme offers a unique way to learn the process needed to bring ideas to life and build a startup. The programme will take individuals through the method to lead them through all of the steps needed to validate and launch their own business. The programme began in January 2022.



NatWest Accelerator

The NatWest Accelerator is a partnership between NatWest and the University of Warwick’s Innovation District. The programme supports and empowers UK entrepreneurs and business owners to scale their businesses to the next level.

Companies that join the programme are given access to hotdesking and event spaces at the heart of the University, while also being provided with space, facilities, experts, and advisors to complement and augment the delivery programme of NatWest.

Graduate Accelerator Programme

The first Graduate Accelerator Programme launched in 2022, with applications for the scheme opening in September 2022. The Programme provides an exciting opportunity for five business teams to develop their entrepreneurial skills, test, launch and pitch their business ideas to industry buyers within 12-months.

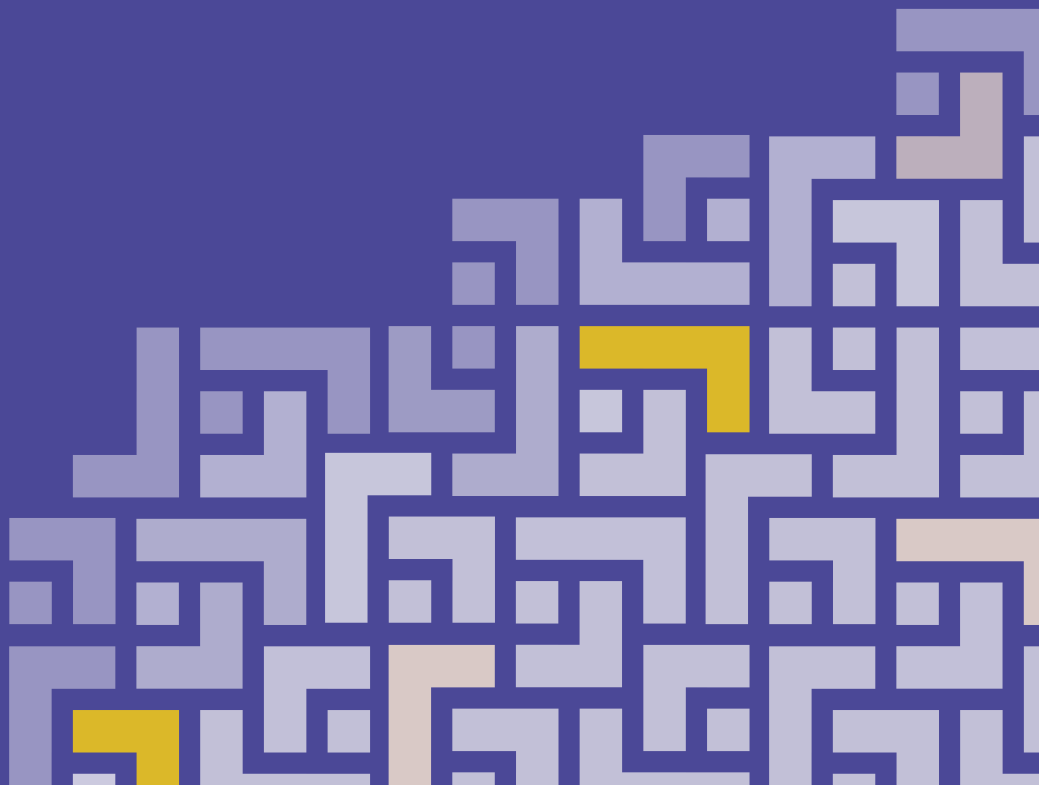
Along the way, participants will clarify their vision, strengthen their mindset and evaluate market opportunities in order to build and launch their business idea. This 12-month venture development journey provides individuals with support and funding, giving them hands-on practical tools and confidence to transform their ideas into a real business.

High Value Manufacturing Catapult

University of Warwick is the lead centre for achieving two of High Value Manufacturing Catapult's strategic objectives of Vehicle Electrification, as well as the development of Connected and Autonomous Vehicles (CAV). It is also active in deploying Digital Manufacturing technologies to improve supply chain competitiveness. Warwick Manufacturing Group (WMG) has worked with over 1,100 companies, creating more than 650 new products and processes, which has saved or protected over 11,500 jobs.

The Warwick Innovation District is helping the industry innovate in a number of key areas, including vehicle electrification, intelligent vehicles, and materials and manufacturing. This is all underpinned by expertise in automation, digital manufacturing technologies and supply chain and operations, enabling more efficient and low-cost manufacturing processes in connected supply chains.

Prognosis



Levelling up

In February 2022, the government announced a new ambitious levelling up programme aimed at addressing regional inequalities. This agenda recognised the excessive centrality of the UK economy in London, outlining the need to ensure that an individual's geography does not dictate their access to opportunities. A core element of the levelling up programme includes investing in ongoing research and development taking place across the nation. For the West Midlands, where innovation stemming from leading universities is rife, this represents a key opportunity to commercialise the world-leading research taking place.

The region has a great capacity to continue developing the cluster of cleantech companies that have emerged within the region. Companies, including renewable energy specialists Tonik and Cogen, have evidenced the West Midlands capacity to support business working to facilitate the energy transition.

A cluster of successful gaming companies surrounding Leamington have emerged in recent years, including mobile and VR studio Pixel Toys, multiple platform developer Playtonic Games, and mobile developer Midoki. Since 2012, these

companies have raised a combined total of £13.2m in equity investment, showcasing the region's ability to foster high-value business communities.

“Levelling Up will help address the imbalance of opportunities across the UK, ensuring better access to qualifications to secure the high-quality, well-paid jobs of the future, and should see the region receiving a greater share of critical research and development funding. The West Midlands has been named as one of the UK's first Innovation Accelerators, bringing further investment to the region. The University of Warwick is playing a pivotal role, as a leader in innovation that has demonstrated ambition, vision and delivery.”

Andy Street, Mayor of the West Midlands

Education

The University of Warwick recognises the importance of innovation and enterprise in the development of future entrepreneurs, but also in the development of employability skills and knowledge for graduates. They offer a catalogue of innovation and enterprise modules that can be taken alongside other degrees, together with a range of post graduate programmes in Innovation and Enterprise. Warwick Manufacturing Group and Warwick Business School provide specialist excellence in this academic field, and link to key sectors of manufacturing, engineering, health, and business.

Warwick Enterprise also offers supporting programmes of innovation and entrepreneurship — two key components of the University's culture and values. By offering support for students and graduates through Warwick Enterprise, the programme has helped various businesses thrive. One of these initiatives is Scrubbee, a sustainable skincare business

that focuses on upcycling by-products from the food industry into cosmetics. In the Fintech industry, the University also supported the creation of Kavida.ai, a supply chain digital twin platform that helps businesses make intelligent resiliency decisions. The company believes that using integrated supply chain data can help its clients unlock superior resilience and is currently implementing a vision to use machine intelligence to predict and manage supply chain disruption risk.

The University of Warwick Science Park Minerva Angel Network has promoted opportunities to invest in Warwick businesses, using the Warwick Business School offices in the Shard London. This important and unique positioning has enabled the growth of Warwick's national angel network, supported by London-based investors providing equity finance to small, West Midlands businesses.



Warwick Enterprise.



Scrubbee.



Kavida.ai.

A multidisciplinary innovation ecosystem

Pioneering innovation and change, companies at the Warwick Innovation District have benefitted from a multi-centre, multidisciplinary innovation ecosystem that harnesses the strengths of a Russell Group University. These businesses span a range of sectors, creating a business community filled with innovation and diversity. Sustainability is a key theme across WID, with companies such as Anvil Semiconductors — a company developing semiconductors for power converters for use in electric cars — spinning out from the University of Warwick.

There are also a number of science-based businesses located in the region, most likely as a result of the high concentration of research intensive universities situated in the West Midlands. NanoSyrinx, for example, spun out of the University of Warwick with the aim of creating a nano-syringe that allows medicine to effectively access the interior of a cell. Moreover, Salinity Solutions, a company spun out from the University of Birmingham, has developed an energy efficient desalination system, with a proprietary use in the process of lithium extraction.

Innovation in action case study



The NanoSyrinx journey highlights the exceptional support from the University of Warwick for ambitious founders, leaders, academics and business owners.

2015

Academic founders attended a lunchtime seminar: 'Support for Translation and Commercialisation' at Warwick.

Appointed Business Development Manager.

Awarded Leverhulme Trust grant of £285k.

Granted EPSRC PhD Studentship.

2016

As part of his PhD, founder Joe Healey attended the 'Business, Innovation & Commercialisation for Researchers' course at Warwick.

Awarded Warwick Impact Fund award of £28k.

2017

Attended Pre-CURE Accelerator to define business model and value propositions.

Conducted FTO study for proof of market.

Granted an ICURE award of £35k.

Conducted customer discovery and market validation.

Awarded Warwick Impact Fund award of £25k.

2018

Granted BBSRC award of £14k.

Conducted independent market research and analysed IP landscape.

Granted EPSRC IAA award of £69k.

2019

Joined Ignite Incubator at the University of Warwick Science Park.

Secured BBSRC Follow on Funding of £250k.

Filed initial patent.

2020

Joined Business Ready at the University of Warwick Science Park.

Secured equity investment and an Innovate UK grant of £610k.

Worked with Warwick Scientific Services.

2021

Secured follow-on equity investment of £6.2m.

Created 10 new technology jobs.

Move to electrification of transport, need for batteries, and high-value manufacturing

In the Government's Levelling Up White Paper, the opportunities for future transport technologies in the West Midlands, in partnership with the Warwick Manufacturing Group, were highlighted as a key innovation cluster to be supported through an increased research and development budget. One example of this, highlighted in the agenda, is Coventry's move to become the first all-electric bus city – a project supported by £50m of Government funding. The report shines a light on the opportunities available in this field for the West Midlands. These continue to be particularly relevant, with COP-21 and sustainable development at the forefront of investors' minds, creating ample opportunities for the region to seize.

High-value manufacturing remains a key priority for the Warwick Innovation District, as it looks to seize more opportunities for the West Midlands.

The University of Warwick's partnership with the High Value Manufacturing Catapult promises to deliver additional support for companies hoping to innovate in this field.

Supporting the energy transition has been a core aim at the Warwick Innovation District, resulting in Coventry's reputation for developing and delivering clean energy batteries. One company that is in the process of doing so is ZPN Energy, a Coventry-based business that develops battery charging technology for electric vehicles. The company has received a total of £3.99m of equity investment since launching in January 2021, alongside £6.45m of grant funding. Similarly, the high-value manufacturer Geothermal International develops and manufactures geothermal heat pumps, and also manages its own clean energy products.



Electric vehicles outside WMG, University of Warwick.

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Beaurost is a searchable database of the UK's high-growth companies.

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The University of Warwick is a thriving Russell Group University. With 30,000 students and a top 10 place in the UK, it is uniquely placed to bring together research and teaching excellence with entrepreneurship. Powered by the University of Warwick, and open to all, the Warwick Innovation District is a large, open innovation ecosystem that stretches from the University Hospitals Coventry and Warwickshire NHS Trust, through Leamington to Wellesbourne.

We bring together academics, businesses, founders, and investors, to start, scale and pivot businesses, while helping students gain the opportunity to experiment with creative and critical thinking. Our passion is to see our region prosper.

To learn more, visit warwickinnovationdistrict.com

